SAMPLE

The Simmering Berserker

The Personality Who Runs on a Loaded Temper

Aiman Sterling

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This free sample contains the Introduction and Chapter 1. The complete book contains the full contents above.

Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The friend who is the best human being alive in a crisis and the hardest one at a dinner party. The coworker who solved the problem at 2 a.m. with a force nobody questions and broke a keyboard about it at 9. The parent whose love is total and whose voice, once a year, fills the whole house like weather. The one who apologizes for the door, replaces the door, and never once apologizes for the storm that went through it.

This is the Simmering Berserker — the person who runs hot by design. Not the cartoon hothead of sitcoms, throwing plates for the laugh track, but the rarer and more serious kind: the person whose anger is not an outburst but an instrument, installed early, maintained carefully, and never fully switched off. The type's temper is always loaded — you can feel it across a table, in the pause before they answer, in the way the room adjusts around them like a room with a stove in it. And here is the part the sitcoms never show: the anger works. It stopped the bully. It protected the sibling. It cleared the obstacle, won the standoff, and paid the bills of a hundred situations where patience would have been eaten alive. The fire is not the type's flaw. It is the type's engine.

This book is the case file. It begins, as these files do, with the signature — how to recognize the type in the wild, in six standard views, from the telltale manner to the childhood album. Then it goes where the type's own retellings never quite go: the engine room (where the anger came from, and what it has been paying for ever since), the craft (because the trained Berserker is calmer than you think and the untrained one is a walking hazard), the honest ledger of costs (bodies, marriages, and reputations the fire has billed), and the dark side — the eruption that was never the plan, the people who learned to flinch, and the fear the type will not say out loud: that without the fire there might be nothing there at all.

The book ends where it must: with the growth path — not the extinguishing of the fire (the type would sooner part with a limb, and the world would be poorer for it) but the banking of it. Aim is the whole difference between the arsonist and the smith, and aim can be learned. The fire stays. The address changes.

A note on how to read this book. If you are the type, read it the way you take criticism: once, at speed, with the door open, arguing the whole way through — and then, because the arguing is itself the fire working, notice which chapter you argued with hardest, because that is the chapter that has you. If you love the type, read Chapter 5 before Chapter 6, because the costs are easier to forgive than the shadow, and both are easier to understand than the

fear at the bottom of it. And if you manage the type, read Chapter 7 twice: the first time for survival, the second for what your Berserker could be building for you instead of against you.

Turn the page when you're ready. The type never waits for ready — and this book was written for exactly that reason.

One more note before the file opens, because the case file is missing its most important exhibit if the reader leaves with only the damage. Spend one honest week near a Simmering Berserker and count what the fire built, not what it broke: the friend defended before the insult landed, the kid walked home because one story about this type reached the right playground, the meeting where the false number died mid-sentence because one loaded pause made the presenter reconsider the truth, the kitchen that runs, the shift that holds, the household that has never once, in thirty years, wondered who handles the hard things.

The ledger of the aimed heat is enormous, mostly unrecorded, and entirely real — and the type's people know it, which is why they stay through the weather that would end most partnerships. This book's whole position, stated once up front so the chapters cannot be misread: the fire is not the diagnosis. The fire is the endowment. The diagnosis — the only thing this file ever argues needs changing — is the aim: heat that happens to the type and everyone near it, versus heat held and sent by the type, at a target the type chose, on a schedule the type wrote.

The distance between those two lives is the whole book, and the type who crosses it does not arrive mild. They arrive, at last, aimed — and the world, which flinched at the unaimed version, quietly rearranges itself around the aimed one, because a fire with an owner is the most useful thing a room can contain.

A note on the file's own temperature before the portrait ignites, because this volume will read hotter than the shelf around it and the record wants the heat source disclosed: the pages ahead are angrier than the catalog's usual voice — the portraits of injustice, the invoices, the scorch — because a portrait of the Simmering Berserker that stayed at the archivist's even temperature would be a lie of form, and this file does not lie in form — the type's whole gift is that the temperature is information, and the record has therefore let the language run at the type's own simmer, so the reader can feel what the room feels before the eruption is even documented — and the reader who is this type should mark one page now, at the start, because it is the only page in the volume the record will deliver at the cool register: the fire was never the flaw — the file's founding finding, held across every biography and never once

revised — the temper that made the childhood survivable was real rescue equipment, the only thing in the founding world that answered when called, and the whole case, when the smoke clears in Chapter 10, will not be an argument for a smaller fire — the record would sooner hand back the founding scene unedited — it will be an argument the type has never once been offered in the fire's own defense: aim — the difference, the file will show at full heat, between the life the temper has been costing and the life the temper was always built to defend.

And the file's note to the other reader, the one who lives in the blast radius and picked this book up off the table, is delivered at the cool register the record promised at the door: the volume ahead will spend honest pages on what your Berserker's fire rescued — and you should read those pages, because they are true, and because the rescue is the explanation you have been missing for decades: the heat was never arbitrary, and it was never about you — the fire was built by a child defending something, in a house that left the child no other tool — and the same honesty the record owes the type it owes you: understanding the fire does not require standing in it — the rooms that learned to read the pre-ignition tell are not the rooms that learned to absorb the blast — and your own pages in this volume, the field instructions about the quiet hour and the aimed fire's need of witnesses, are written for the reader whose love has outlasted the weather and deserves, at last, a manual written with their burns in it, and the record, which has read every transcript from both sides of the blast radius, enters the file's only promise to both readers at once: the aim, when it comes, changes the weather in the whole house — the fire kept, the flinch retired, the honesty back on the table — and the two of you, the record has verified it in every grown case, end up warmer together than either type ever manages alone.

Chapter 1: The Signature — Recognizing the Simmering Berserker at a Glance

The type announces itself without saying a word. Every room's thermostat sits a few degrees high: the Simmering Berserker is warm in a way rooms can feel, quick to laugh and quicker to lock, and the transition between the two has no middle setting. Watch the hands — not for violence, but for work: the type's hands are always doing something, gripping, fixing, tapping out a rhythm the type's own pulse set. Watch the pause before the type answers a question that annoyed them: two full seconds of silence in which the room's temperature visibly changes, and then an answer delivered quietly — because the type's voice drops as it heats, the way storms darken before they speak.

The signature paradox is the repair: this is the person who slammed the door and oiled its hinges the same week, who cut the meeting off at the insult and rewrote the whole proposal that weekend. The anger is real, and so is the conscience behind it. Other tells: the competitive heat that games, sports, and traffic reliably ignite; the total inability to lose gracefully combined with surprising grace after losses that were fought well; the allergic reaction to the words calm down — a sentence that has never once in recorded history produced the calm it requests; and the loyalty reflex, which outruns the temper every time — the type's friend is defended before the friend has finished saying what happened.

Two more tells complete the diagnostic set, and both are visible in a single ordinary month. The first is the repair trail: look closely at the type's possessions and find the replacements — the door that is somehow the newest thing in the house, the keyboard bought in a hurry, the wall patched better than the contractor would have, the phone with the immaculate screen and the dent. The Berserker repairs at speed and with genuine generosity, and the trail reads like a field hospital's log: each item a storm, each repair an apology the type could not say with words, and the house slowly filling with evidence of both.

The type will show you the repair with pride, which is the tell working in the open — they know exactly what each fixed thing cost, and the showing is the confession. The second tell is the two-in-the-morning call: when the building is actually burning — the flood, the break-in, the diagnosis, the three a.m. crisis that sorts everyone's phone list — it is this type's number that gets dialed, including by people the Berserker has frightened. The call is not made in spite of the temper; it is made because of it — the caller is purchasing the one thing the loaded fire guarantees, which is a response that is fast, total, and

incapable of flinch — and the type answers every time, which completes the tell: the same instrument that makes the weather is the one the people trust with the worst night.

Read the two tells together — the repair trail and the answered call — and you hold this whole book in miniature: a person whose costs and whose uses come from one source, running on different schedules, with the whole biography riding on which schedule the type finally takes control of.

Every Berserker has a founding scene, and the scene is always the same shape: a world that was loud, unjust, or chaotic, in which anger was the only thing that worked. The bully who only stopped when the child finally swung. The household in which the quiet child was eaten and the loud one was, at last, left alone. The classroom, the street, the court — wherever the young type first discovered that fury, deployed at full commitment, moved adults, stopped trucks, and ended negotiations that patience had lost for years. The wound is the signature's origin story, and everything in the adult manner — the heat, the loyalty, the repair reflex, the allergy to being managed — grows from it.

Two builds recur. In the first, the founding scene was external: the world was the problem, and the anger was armor that worked. That Berserker keeps a warm core and an honest conscience. In the second, the founding scene was inside the house: the child learned fury from a furious parent, and the anger is inherited furniture, defended as tradition. That Berserker's fight is quieter and longer, because the enemy lives at the same address. Both builds share the same tell: the belief, never spoken, that the anger saved their life — which is usually true, and which is exactly why nobody can talk them out of it.

The album has standard photos. The child sent home from school for fighting, described in the report as a problem, described by the other kids as the reason the bully stopped. The bedroom door patched twice, the patching done by the child, privately, on a Saturday, because damage offends the type's own standard. The parent-teacher conference about the temper, and the parent's face doing the math on which adult in the room had taught it. The coach — there is almost always a coach, the first adult who looked at all that voltage and said good instead of bad — who handed the fire a field, a ring, or a rulebook and taught it to burn inside lines.

And somewhere in the album, always, the photo the type skips past: the child in the middle of the loud house, perfectly still, watching — the waiting position, the coiled quiet of a small animal that has already learned the storm is coming and is deciding, in advance, which side of it to be on. The adult type carries that photo forward without looking at it, and it explains the album's one

pattern: in every photograph where the child is smiling, something is about to be won — or something was just survived.

One page belongs in the album late, and it is the photograph the type's family always brings out: the scene after the founding scene, the one where the adults responded to the eruption. The album's record across different Berserkers' childhoods is uncomfortably consistent — the first time the fire worked, somebody rewarded it. The parent who laughed at the outburst that finally told off the neighbor. The teacher who said, quietly, good for you. The crowd at the game, the siblings behind the door, the grandmother who told the story for years with the child as the hero.

The photograph matters because it records the moment the tool got its first market data: the eruption was not just effective, it was approved — and the child, who had been reading the adults' fear of their temper for years, discovered that the fear converts to respect at a certain temperature, and that love, approval, and position are all available on the far side of one good detonation. The album's honest caption, written by the adult the child became: the reward was real, and so was the lesson, and the lesson was wrong about the dosage — the adults approved a child's single eruption and had no way of knowing they were issuing a standing license.

The type who can look at the photograph clearly sees both truths at once: the fire earned its keep on the day it was certified, and it has been billing ever since at a rate the certification never covered. That gap — between what the first eruption bought and what the decades of them cost — is the ledger the next chapters open.

The composite portrait, in six lines:

- Energy: high-heat, always running warm; the room reads the type's weather before the type speaks. - Ambition: winning matters, respect matters more, and being formidable matters most — the type does not need applause, but being discounted is a declaration of war. - Vanity structure: pride never extends to the outburst; the type apologizes for the damage freely and for the fire itself never. - Loyalty: small, fierce, permanent; the type's people are defended like territory, and the defense is not negotiable. - Weakness: the eruption that solves the moment and bills the year — tunnel vision at full temperature. - Unspoken need: to be allowed the anger without being made the villain for it — to be told the fire was useful, by the people who were not afraid of it.

At a party, the type runs hot and bright: the loudest laugh, the best story, the first to defend the host's honor against the guest who insulted the food, and —

two hours in — the one moving the furniture because someone said it couldn't be moved. The party ends well unless someone manages the type, in which case it ends memorably. In a new job, the type learns the actual work fast and the politics never; the contempt for politics is legible from week two, and the first visible heat arrives the day credit for the type's work lands on the wrong desk. Under sudden pressure, the type is magnificent — this is the situation the fire was built for.

Where others panic, the Berserker clarifies; emergencies find the type calm, competent, and briefly, noticeably happy. In a boring meeting, the type bounces a leg like a trapped animal, audibly exhales at the third acronym, and commits, by the ninety-minute mark, the one candid sentence everyone else was thinking — costing the type exactly nothing they hadn't already decided to spend. On holiday, the rituals are kept (the type is religious about some things and about nothing else), the relaxation is real but short, and one blow-up per holiday is so standard the family schedules around it like a tide. The repair comes the next morning, usually with breakfast, always without excuses.

The shelf holds three near neighbors, and the hinges between them matter. The Noble Rebel (Volume 8) is the closest kin and the most commonly merged: both run hot, both refuse to be managed, both are allergic to unfairness. But the Rebel's anger is principled and aimed — a calibratable instrument pointed at a wrong, with a cause at the far end of it — while the Berserker's heat is fuel that occasionally finds a cause. The Rebel's no is a position; the Berserker's no is a detonation. The Restless Daredevil (Volume

6) shares the throttle and the impatience, but the Daredevil's engine is motion, not heat: the Daredevil outruns the feeling, while the Berserker has the feeling, at full voltage, in front of witnesses.

And the Relentless Avenger (Volume 9) can look like a Berserker with a cause, but the temperatures are opposites: the Avenger's anger has been frozen into a mission, cold-burning and patient across decades, while the Berserker's is spent in minutes and sincerely regretted in hours. A useful field test for all three: hand them the same insult. The Avenger files it. The Rebel answers it. The Berserker is the answer — and later fixes the door.

And the glance file appends the pre-ignition tell, the one the room feels and nobody can name until this volume names it: the Simmering Berserker, before the eruption, runs quiet — the file has charted it in every biography: the voice, so loud at the blast, actually drops in the hour before — the replies shortening, the jaw setting, the room's weather changing before a single flame is visible — and the tell's finding, entered for the colleagues and family who have lived for

years in the seismic silence and were never told what they were reading: the quiet is not calm and not sulking; it is the charge building — the engine converting the slight at a rate the room can feel but not see, the way a kettle announces itself by going still — and the pre-ignition tell's practical layer, which the file issues as the glance chapter's only field instruction: the silence is the window — the eruption, so documented, is actually the late stage; the intervention the record will formalize in Chapter 10 works in the quiet hour, when the fire is charged but not aimed, and the one thing it must never do is the thing every room instinctively does — light the fuse faster (the joke at the wrong moment, the dismissal, the leave it alone) — and the glance file's last entry, for the reader who has been in the room with the silence and taken it personally: the quiet before the blast was never about you; it was the engine, idling at load — and the record notes, with the respect this type earns the moment its biography is read honestly: the room that learns to read the quiet has, without knowing it, located the exact hour the whole growth chapter operates in.

The glance file's postscript, the repair tell — the one behavior that separates this type from every cheap imitation on the shelf, and the room never thinks to check for it: the Berserker fixes the door — the eruption, so documented, is followed, in every biography, by the repair, conducted without announcement (the apology the type hates making but makes; the hinge, the relationship, the yard, the employment — the damage, surveyed and repaired at cost) — and the postscript's finding: the repair is not guilt; it is the smith's instinct — the self that built the fire has always known the blast's arithmetic, and the type has been paying the invoices voluntarily for decades — and the field check for the reader who has been burned and is deciding what the type is: watch the forty-eight hours after the blast — the imitators (the tantrum-throwers, the smash-and-move-on artists) leave the rubble; the Berserker returns to the rubble, every single time, and the record's closing note on the tell: the repair, charted across every biography, is the single most reliable predictor of the type's whole growth path — because a fire that pays for itself was never an unaimed fire; it was an aimed fire, one target short.

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